

A Brief Guide to IL for BANZSL

ABOUT

What is IL?

IL stands for **Iconic Logography** – it is an experimental writing system for sign languages, specifically British Sign Language (BSL), Auslan and New Zealand Sign Language (NZSL). It is currently just a proof of concept.

Why Those Languages?

BSL, Auslan and NZSL are similar enough to be mutually intelligible to one another. Thus by using each of their strengths, they can share a writing system – and in doing so potentially bridge each Deaf community to one another.

With further use, each language would likely become at least somewhat distinct in how it used IL.

What is a Logography?

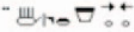
A logographic is a type of writing system that represents each word (in this case sign) with an individual character / glyph representing the meaning. This is called a logogram.

What is a Iconicity?

Iconicity is a property of sign languages that means that signs tend to look like what they are describing. This is leveraged to make logograms.

Why a Logography?

Other sign language writing systems have been attempted – usually focusing on depicting the sign itself. These are often inefficient or require a decoding process. IL attempts to leverage the iconicity already present in sign languages in order to create an efficient, easier to learn and meaningful writing system.

	Sign Writing	Stokoe	HamNoSys
what?		$E_a E_a z \sim$	

Do Sign Languages Need Writing?

No. Deaf communities express a general lack of need for writing systems for their languages, especially in the era of cameras – when a recording can do it better.

This project is merely for fun. If it is ever used seriously by the Deaf community or Deaf education then that is an added bonus.

The following guide assumes at least an intermediate understanding of at least one sign language and sign language linguistics.

ADJECTIVES

Adjectives are the simplest part of IL. You attach them to nouns on either side according to the grammar of BSL, Auslan or NZSL.



BALL RED

or



RED BALL

or

Red ball.

NOUNS

Nouns are relatively simple in IL.

In all three BANZSL languages the placement of nouns is very important. As such placement can be affixed onto the end of nouns as follows;



BALL 3.SG MR.

or



BALL MR.

or

The ball(right).

3.SG - third person singular pronoun - "it", "he", "she", "they", "this", "that"

MR. - Middle Right - right hand placement

more on this later...

In the case of nouns & adjectives together, put the placement after the both of them.



BALL RED 3.SG MR.

or



RED BALL MR.

or

The ball(right).

VERBS

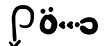
Verbs are more complex – they require more attention to learn. The directionality of verbs matters a lot to BSL, Auslan and NZSL. For the purposes of IL they can be broken down into three categories;

- **V 0-DIR** – 0 Directional Verbs
- **V 1-DIR** – 1 Directional Verbs
- **V 2-DIR** – 2 Directional Verbs

0 Directional Verbs are always signed the same way with no significant placement or directional changes. They can be written without any additions.

2 Directional Verbs are verbs that have an active movement with a variable start and end point. The placement of both the start and end point must be specified.

1 Directional Verbs are verbs that do move but either the start or endpoint is fixed. Alternatively – verbs that can be placed in space are considered 1 Directional Verbs.

IL	IL in Use	Verb Type	Gloss	English	Other Notes
	 I ate.	V 0-DIR	EAT	<i>to eat</i>	This verb is always in the same place, so needs no placement marker.
	 I posted.	V 1-DIR	POST	<i>to post</i>	This verb always starts in the same place so the placement at the end shows the destination.
	 I danced.	V 1-DIR	DANCE	<i>to dance</i>	This verb can be placed, but once placed does not move from that placement – so the placement is indicated before it.
	 I moved.	V 2-DIR	MOVE	<i>to move _ (to) _</i>	This verb has a start and end point that can be changed. Thus these must be indicated with a placement before and after it.

PLACEMENTS

This is where you may have to begin memorising. Placements are critical to sign language grammar and so are given their own characters. However, these are simplified for ease of use.

Left to Right

↓	↓	.	↗	↘
far left	left	middle	right	far right

"I moved the box." — □↓↘↗↘↗

This is styled after holding your hands in an L shape to determine your left and right hands.

The middle dot is also the midpoint of the sign-space in general, not just the left-to-right scale. It can also be used as a placement marker, as shown in the Bodypart section.

Above & Below

↖	↖	↖
above left	above	above right
↘	↘	↘
below left	below	below right

"I brought the box down." - □↖↘↘↘↘

These are stylised after the head and chin – though only loosely because they indicate any degree of above or below.

Fore & Aft

١

fore left

fore

fore right

L

aft left

aft

aft right

"I put the box in front." - □_↓ ρ_L ११३ 7

This is stylised after the corners of a box placed in front of you.

Arm & Shoulder

۲۰۰۰

over
shoulder

near
shoulder

away from
shoulder

1

L

opposite
shoulder

elbow

mid-arm

wrist

“The box was stationary, then it was moved about” – 

These are placements primarily used in timelines.

Personal



me



you



them(present)

“I give the box to you.” -

These are used to place signs near the relevant person. You should NOT use these as pronouns.

The *them(present)* specifically refers to someone / group presently in the room, rather than something placed in sign-space.

Bodypart



back



chest



head



leg



legs



belly



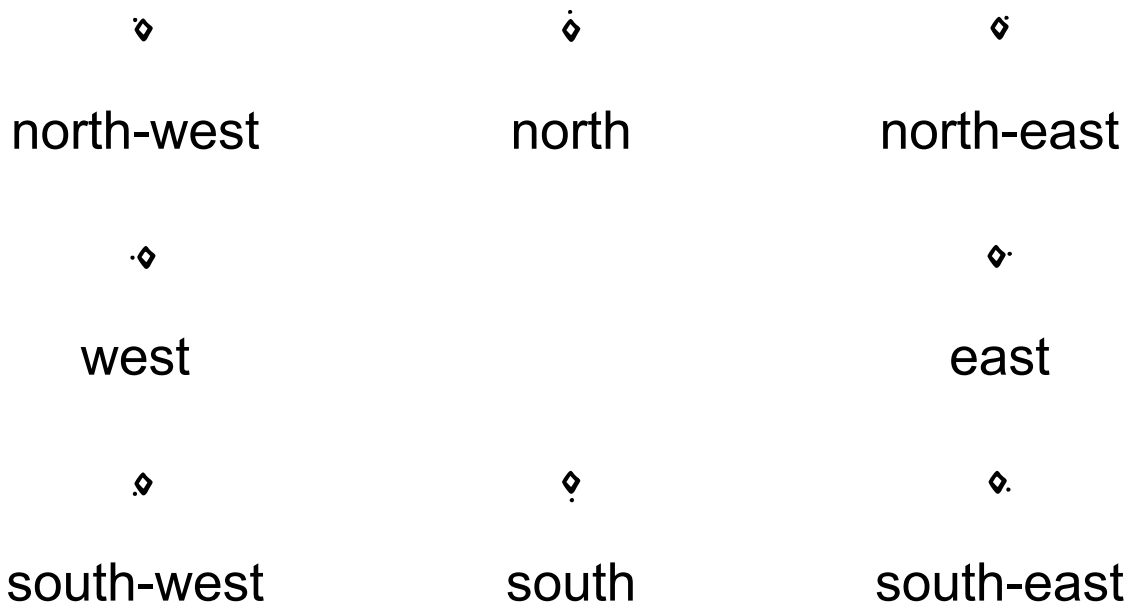
foot

“Now the box is on my head.” -

The use of the middle dot before these indicates that these are placements rather than the signs for the various bodyparts. Other placements can be used to narrow down where on each bodypart the sign is placed.

Though in the case of the foot, it would be placed on the a classifier of the foot rather than the foot itself.

Relative



These are placements deliberately left vague in order to be used in cases where other examples do not work – or in cases where the precise placement in sign-space doesn't matter but the relative orientation of two signs / classifiers does.

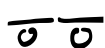
QUESTIONS

There are numerous ways to form questions in IL, intended to match the ways that questions can be formed in the BAZNSL languages.

Question Words



What?



Where?



When?



Who?



Why?



Which?



How?



How old?



How much?



How many?

Question words, of course follow at the end of a sentence, or can be used as a rhetorical question to conjoin two ideas.

Some notable question words that have more rules are;

◁▷ - By default it moves left-right but this can be modified with placements.

◁▷ - vertical which

◁▷, ◁▷ & ◁▷ can also mean “age”, “price”, “many” and “reason”.

Question Punctuation

?

:

⁂?

⁂:

?

(question mark)

:

(colon)

Question
NMF

Rhetorical
NMF

The question mark and colon can be used for questions and rhetoricals respectively, when the question word falls at the end of a sentence.

☞ 👤 👤 ⁂? - Who is that?

☞ 👤 👤 ⁂: 🎅! - That is Father Christmas!

Alternatively, the question NMFs can be used, especially if another word needs to be turned into a question word.

☞ 👤 👤 🎅 ⁂? ... - That is Father Christmas...?

☞ 👤 👤 🎅 ⁂: — 🙄 — That is Father Christmas... I'm dissapointed.

PRONOUNS

Pronouns in IL follow simple systems intended to be learnt easily.

Personal Pronouns

𐌱	𐌲	𐌳	𐌴
I, me	we, us	you(single)	you(plural)
1.SG	1.PL	2.SG	2.PL
𐌵	𐌶	𐌷	
it, him, her, them(single)	them(plural)	both	
3.SG	3.PL	DUAL	

Pronouns can have placements added in order to specify further.

𐌲𐌱 - "Us (not you)..."

𐌳𐌴 - "You on the left..."

𐌴𐌵 - "You lot on the right..."

𐌵𐌶𐌷 - "Him over there on the left..."

𐌶𐌷𐌵 - "Them over there on the right..."

𐌱𐌷𐌲 - "Both you and me"

Possessive Pronouns

Ø

possessive

POS

Ø_v

my

1.SG.POS

Ø_g

our

1.PL.POS

Ø[^]

your(single)

2.SG.POS

Ø[~]

your(plural)

2.PL.POS

Ø_v

its, his, her, their(single)

3.SG.POS

Ø_v

their(plural)

3.PL.POS

Once again these can have placements added to specify who is being referred to.

The POS (Ø) in can be used flexibly & creatively to create new possessive placements.

CLASSIFIERS

Classifiers are key components of sign languages, which very few sign language writing systems are able to faithfully represent. IL attempts to leverage the creative nature of classifiers in a 2D medium.

Firstly it is important to note that a written language can never be 1:1 to its spoken/signed counterpart. There will always be something lost – such as intonation, and some things work better in speech/sign, others work better in text. Classifiers are one such area where it is impossible to capture 1:1, but a similar meaning can be relayed.

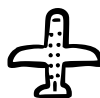
Object Classifiers



person



vehicle



plane



pebble



bubble



leg



legs



foot



head



wall

These represent objects that can be depicted with individual handshapes. Other simple nouns can be used as object classifiers.

Handling Classifiers



general hold



thin hold



thick hold

These are used to indicate handling of different things.

Tracing Classifiers



pen



square



circle

The pen can be used to indicate a 2D drawing. The square can be used to indicate a boxy or jagged shape, circle can be used to indicate a rounded shape.

Orientation



flat



upright



sideways



outward



inward

These are orientations, that can modify the classifiers.

 – A person standing up.

 – A person laying down.

Placements

In addition to all of the placements in the **PLACEMENTS** section, the following modifiers can be added to influence placement of two classifiers relative to each other;



touching



near



far

 – Two people standing shoulder to shoulder.

 – Two people standing near to each-other.

 – Two people standing far from each-other.

Movements



north-west



north



north-east



west

Smooth
Movement



east



south-west



south



south-east



north-west



north



north-east



west

Wiggle



east



south-west



south



south-east

These can be added to classifiers to indicate movement. The direction is left vague in order to be used flexibly and creatively. Placements can be added for clarification.

  - "The person left..."

   - "The person came towards me..."



north clockwise arc



south clockwise arc



south anti-clockwise arc



north anti-clockwise arc



east clockwise arc



west anti-clockwise arc



west clockwise arc



east anti-clockwise arc



clockwise circle



anti-clockwise circle

Similarly to the above, these indicate the movement of classifiers in a flexible way.

 - "The people danced in circles around each-other."

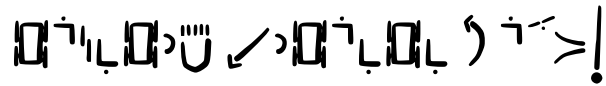
In addition to use in classifiers, all movements can be utilised as modifiers to verb also.

 - "We travelled a long way to visit [them]."

Combination

Due to the flexible and creative nature of classifiers, there is no set order to them. However – it is good advice to set up the classifiers and their locations before moving them for clarity.

In addition it is suggested that in cases of two classifiers, it follow the signer's perspective, with the left as the left hand and the right as the right.



– “One car was behind the other, until [they] slammed [their] foot on the peddle, overtook and zoomed off.”

NMFs & MODIFIERS

Non-Manual Features

😊

happy

😡

annoyed

😠

angry

😬

awkward

😞

sad

😮

surprised

😵

confused

❓

question / unsure

❗

faux-question

These can be added after signs or whole sentences to indicate specific facial NMFs you want to add.

👉 👤 🎅 😮!/? - "That's father Christmas!?"

👉 👤 🎅 😞!/? - "That's father Christmas!?"

While the English text for these two sentences is the same – it is clear the difference in meaning these two sentences convey!

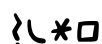
❓ ❗

One other use for these NMFs is to indicate that a question is being asked in general, but not to the reader. Please see the **Role Shifts / Quotations** section for an example.

Modifiers

Modifiers are similar to NMFs, but they affect how the sign itself is signed.

		
break	energetic	slow
		
quick	hard	not / negative



These all do what their name suggests. They change a sign to be signed energetically, slowly, quickly and hard.



This modifier causes a sign (usually a verb) that would not normally break apart or stop, to otherwise break apart or reverse.

 – Communication breakdown.



This negates a sign, usually with a shake of the head or a scrunch of the face. This is technically an NMF but (currently) fits better into the modifier category for the purposes of IL.

A complimentary affirmative sign will be added in future.

NUMBERS

The number system in IL is simple. It combines Arabic numerals and the numbers as seen across different dialects of BSL, Auslan and NZSL.

1

2^u

3^u

4^u

5^u

6^s

7^s

8^s

9^s

0

The numbers 0 and 1 are left untouched because the sign and the number line up 1:1.

The numbers 2-5 contain upright dashes to indicate fingers being held upright.

The numbers 6-9 contain sideways dashes to indicate fingers being held sideways.

Ordinal numbers used for counting lists (like 1st, 2nd, 3rd) are planned to be added in the future.

PUNCTUATION

.

. (full stop / interpunct)

!

! (exclamation mark)

?

? (question mark)

,

, (comma)

—

— (dash)

:

:

• VS •

The full stop / interpunct should not be confused with the middle dot. While superficially similar the full stop / interpunct is thicker than the middle dot.

This may be amended in future drafts.

!

The exclamation mark works as expected, conveying a number of different emotional states across an entire sentence.

? & :

The role of question mark and colon in displaying questions and rhetorical/conjoining-questions is explained further in the **QUESTIONS** section.

› & — & ...

The comma is used to indicate a clause or break up a text with or without a pause. A dash, on the other hand, always indicates a pause in signing. Ellipses likewise serves a similar role of a long pause

Role Shifts / Quotations

Role shifts are used in BSL, Auslan and NZSL to pretend to be other characters (and sometimes objects), and often to quote others. Thus quotation has been implemented along with role shift.

“...”

on the left

“...”

left-above

“...”

left-below

“...”

on the right

“...”

right-above

“...”

right-below

These placements indicate where the quoted person themselves is placed, NOT the direction they are facing.

Thus “...” is actually *facing right* when you sign, as you *role shift into the person on the left*.

This may seem counter-intuitive at first, but consider a situation where you have set up both sides of a discussion on the left and right – and want to clearly read what each is saying.

Two children are sat arguing about whether is father Christmas real...

“Santa is real! Christmas day I wake up and there are loads of new presents and stuff. Santa brings them!”

“He isn't real. I saw our parents bringing them.”